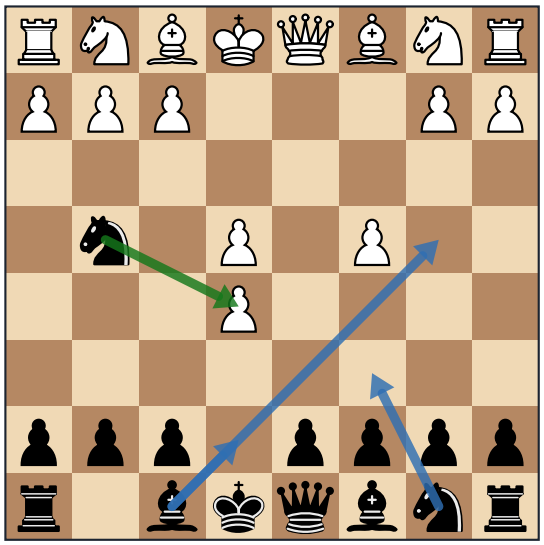
Indian Defense

ECO A43-E60 | 53 named lines | Nimzo / Queen's Indian / Catalan family

In one sentence: Flexible, high-level systems: Black controls e4 with pieces; White fights with the bishop pair, the center or a fianchetto.

Memory pattern: Control e4 with pieces, then break with ...d5 or ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ng4 4.e4

Key ideas

1. Nimzo: pin Nc3 and fight for e4; trade the bishop for knight to damage structure.
2. Queen's Indian: Bb7 and ...Be7 control e4 without weaknesses.
3. Catalan: use the long diagonal and queenside pressure.
4. Bogo-Indian: solid, flexible and low-risk for Black.
5. Plans revolve around e4, the c-file, and whether White gets the bishop pair.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.55** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best: Nxe5.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black controls e4 with pieces (pin on c3 or Bb7) while White takes the c4/d4 centre or the bishop pair. Catalan: White uses g3/Bg2 pressure on d5 and the long diagonal.
2. Where does my king go?	Kings castle short; Black often keeps a healthy pawn structure by giving up the bishop pair.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bb4/Bb7 and the long diagonal. White: Nc3, Bd3, Qc2, e4 break; Catalan: Bg2, Qc2, Nbd2.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White occupies the centre with e4 or plays a3/Bxc3 structures; Black strikes with ...d5/...c5 and piece pressure.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants the bishop pair and a big centre; Black wants to restrain e4 and hit the centre.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ng4 4.e4

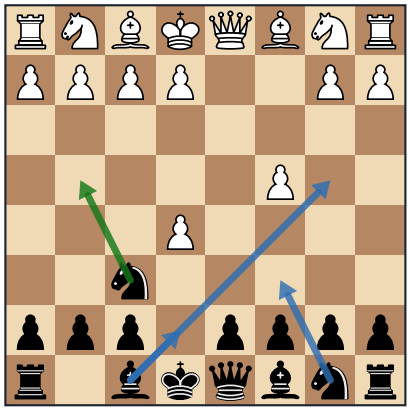
Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
2. c4	Space. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
3. dxe5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
3... Ng4	Repositions the knight to a more active square.
4. e4	Central break. Occupies the center with a pawn.



After 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

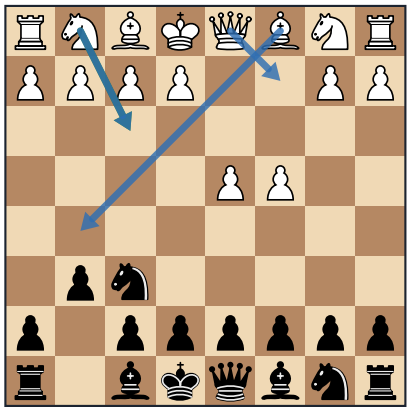


Position after the line

Budapest Gambit Accepted A51 | 10 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5`

Stockfish: **+0.60** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Ng4.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Main Line, Fajarowicz Defense



Position after the line

Anti-Grünfeld E60 | 5 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6`

Stockfish: **+0.52** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Nf3.
What to look for: d4 (take the center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Alekhine Variation, Adorjan Gambit, Advance Variation, Basman-Williams Attack



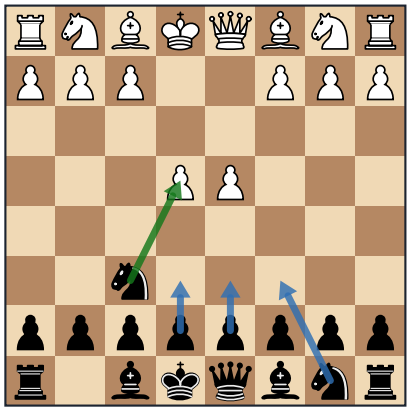
Position after the line

Gibbins-Weidenhagen Gambit A45 | 4 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.g4`

Stockfish: **-0.74** (slightly better for Black, depth 15). Best next move: Nxg4.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Maltese Falcon, Oshima Defense, Stummer Gambit

Position after the line



Position after the line

Omega Gambit A45 | 2 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.e4`

Stockfish: **-0.61** (slightly better for Black, depth 15). Best next move: Nxe4.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Arafat Gambit

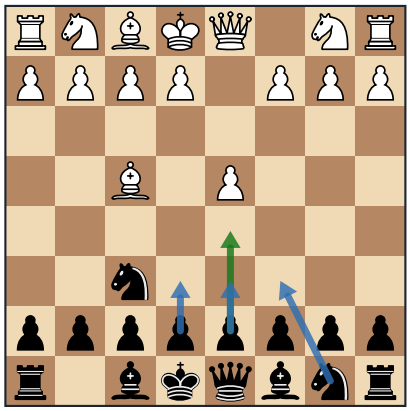


Position after the line

Knights Variation A46 | 2 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.27** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: e6.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Alburt-Miles Variation



Position after the line

Accelerated London System A45 | 1 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.Bf4`

Stockfish: **+0.22** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)

Expert and coach view

Nimzowitsch (Nimzo-Indian), Karpov and Kramnik (Catalan) are strongly linked to these systems.

What a coach would tell you

Learn the key structure: doubled c-pawns versus bishop pair (Nimzo), the long diagonal fight (Catalan) and the e4 break. Play solid, flexible moves and avoid early commitments.

Why play it

Flexible, high-level systems: Black controls e4 with pieces; White fights with the bishop pair, the center or a fianchetto.

Typical mistakes

- Giving up the bishop pair without compensation (Nimzo).
- Playing ...d5 too early before the pieces are developed.
- Letting White play e4 with a big center unopposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxc3 followed by Ng5 or e4 winning the pinned knight if Black is careless.
- Qa4+ forks after ...b5 in Catalan lines.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced endgames with small edges decided by structure and bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Indian Defense (all lines)** — A45
  `1.d4 Nf6`
  - **Accelerated London System** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Bf4`
  - **Gibbins-Weidenhagen Gambit** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.g4`
    - **Oshima Defense** — A45
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.g4 -> 2...e5`
    - **Maltese Falcon** — A45
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.g4 -> 2...Nxg4 3.f3 Nf6 4.e4`
    - **Stummer Gambit** — A45
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.g4 -> 2...Nxg4 3.e4 d6 4.Be2 Nf6 5.Nc3`
  - **Knights Variation** — A46
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3`
    - **Alburt-Miles Variation** — A46
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 -> 2...a6`
  - **Normal Variation** — A50
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4`
  - **Omega Gambit** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.e4`
    - **Arafat Gambit** — A45
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.e4 -> 2...Nxe4 3.Bd3 Nf6 4.Bg5`
  - **Pawn Push Variation** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.d5`
  - **Tartakower Attack** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.g3`
  - **Anti-Grünfeld** — E60
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 g6`
    - **Advance Variation** — E60
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 -> 3.d5`
    - **Alekhine Variation** — E60
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 -> 3.f3`
      - **Leko Gambit** — E60
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.f3 -> 3...e5`
    - **Basman-Williams Attack** — E60
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 -> 3.h4`
    - **Adorjan Gambit** — E60
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 -> 3.d5 b5`
  - **Budapest Gambit** — A51
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 e5`
  - **Czech-Indian** — A46
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 c6`
  - **Gibbins-Weidenhagen Gambit Accepted** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.g4 Nxg4`
  - **Lazard Gambit** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nd2 e5`
  - **Maddigan Gambit** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nc3 e5`
  - **Medusa Gambit** — A50
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 g5`
  - **Polish Variation** — A46
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 b5`
  - **Pyrenees Gambit** — A50
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 b5`
  - **Reversed Chigorin Defense** — A45
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nc3 c5`
  - **Spielmann-Indian** — A46
    `1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 c5`

- **Wade-Tartakower Defense** A46
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 d6
- **West Indian Defense** E60
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 g6
- **Anti-Nimzo-Indian** E10
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3
- **Budapest Gambit Accepted** A51
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5
  - **Fajarowicz Defense** A51
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 -> 3...Ne4
    - **Bonsdorf Variation** A51
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ne4 -> 4.a3
    - **Steiner Variation** A51
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ne4 -> 4.Qc2
  - **Main Line** A52
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 -> 3...Ng4
    - **Adler Variation** A52
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ng4 -> 4.Nf3
    - **Alekhine Variation** A52
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ng4 -> 4.e4
      - **Abonyi Variation** A52
        1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ng4 4.e4 -> 4...Nxe5
      - **Tartakower Defense** A52
        1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ng4 4.e4 -> 4...d6
    - **Rubinstein Variation** A52
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ng4 -> 4.Bf4
- **Devin Gambit** E00
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 e6 3.g4
- **Gedult Attack** A45
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.f3 d5 3.g4
- **London System** A46
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 e6 3.Bf4
- **Paleface Attack** A45
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.f3 d5 3.e4
  - **Blackmar-Diemer Gambit Deferred** A45
    1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.e4
- **Przepiorka Variation** A49
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 g6 3.g3
- **Seirawan Attack** E00
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 e6 3.Bg5
- **Dzindzi-Indian Defense** E10
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 a6
- **Döry Indian** E10
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Ne4
- **Pseudo-Benko** A43
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 c5 3.d5 b5
- **Schnepper Gambit** A47
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 b6 3.c3 e5
- **Colle System** A48
  1.d4 Nf6 -> 2.Nf3 g6 3.e3 Bg7 4.Bd3 d6
  - **King's Indian Variation** A48
    1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.e3 Bg7 4.Bd3 d6

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 Ng4 4.e4
```

Plan chain

White	d4 -> c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> g3
Black	Nf6 -> e6 -> Bb4 -> b6 -> Bb7

Three rules to remember

1. Control e4 with pieces, then break with ...d5 or ...c5.

2. White occupies the centre with e4 or plays a3/Bxc3 structures; Black strikes with ...d5/...c5 and piece pressure.

3. White wants the bishop pair and a big centre; Black wants to restrain e4 and hit the centre.

Pawn structure in one line

Black controls e4 with pieces (pin on c3 or Bb7) while White takes the c4/d4 centre or the bishop pair. Catalan: White uses g3/Bg2 pressure on d5 and the long diagonal.